

Few admit it, but the money certainly isn't a draw. Shedding their starry status and astronomical fees that ranges between Rs 35,000 to Rs 1 lakh for a day's shoot on TV, these aspiring stars are settling for as measly an amount as Rs 1 lakh for a role in a film. Undeniably, it is the glitz of the silver screen which beckons them. "All actors clamour to be a part of the film industry. So they don't mind losing out on money. What matters is that they are in the movies," says Grewal, who will be directing Aamna Shariff, 25, in *Aloo Chaat*. Giving up her simple girl image a miss, Shariff a.k.a. Kashish in *Kahiin To Hoga*, has shed a few kilos to play a trendy Delhi girl opposite Aftab Shivdasani in the film. Giving up a steady income for a film may be a gamble, but it seems worth the risk. For most small screen divas, this is their first big step to stardom on the 35mm entertainment medium. Tired of long shooting hours and done-to-death plots, TV stars

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Shama Sikander, 26

Better known as: Pooja, the simple Gujarati teenager in *Yeh Meri Life Hai*.
The makeover: Will sizzle in an item number in Ram Gopal Varma's *Contract*. She has also bagged the lead role opposite Sameer Dattani in *Dhoom Dhadaka*.

It is this quest for a glamorous experience that saw Shweta Salve and Sangeeta Ghosh sign on producer Dharmesh Darshan's next, *Bhanvraa*. "Films have a greater longevity. For an actor, it's a much bigger platform to perform and gain recognition," says Salve, who played Tina in *Kittie Party*. With over a dozen projects in her kitty, the sexy siren of television is sure to add the oomph factor in skimpy and belly-baring outfits as the romantic lead opposite Manav Gohil. While Salve was looking for fame, Ghosh, 26, desperately wanted to break out of the tear-jerker Pammi image she had portrayed for six years in *Des Mein Nikla Hoga Chaand*. Her portrayal may have raked in TRPs, but for Ghosh, it had "limited scope". So when Darshan offered her Priya's role in *Bhanvraa*, she grabbed it. Big banners though are not their sole consideration. Rucha Gujarathi, 24, better known as Suhana of *Bhabhi* opted out of the show to play Soha, a girl-next-door in the Prabhu-directed *Lottery*, just to break away from the monotony of TV. "There is no experimentation in TV," she says.

The growing relationship between filmmakers and telly actors is symbiotic. New faces, bulk dates, low fees and a strong training ground in histrionics ensures quick turnaround films—good for both filmmakers as well as actors. Moreover, filmmakers are aiming to cash in on their fan following. "They are already stars in their own right and their charisma may just help pull in moms and grand-moms, who avidly followed them in serials," says Grewal. But will these small screen celebs help rake in moolah at the box-office? Trade pundits are not sure about the fate of their films. "Few would go to a theatre to see them when there are bigger stars in Bollywood to watch," says a trade analyst. But if their glam makeover manages to woo audiences, these small screen stars will not only shine in Bollywood constellation but also set the cash registers ringing. ■

vying for their share of fame and fortune prefer to try their luck in Bollywood.

Making a big screen debut opposite director-turned-actor Akhtar may just not be everyone's luck, but other leading ladies of the telly world are not far behind. Like Shama Sikander, who played a bubbly Gujarati teenager in *Yeh Meri Life Hai*, will give up her girl-next-door image to sizzle in a steamy item number in Varma's next, *Contract*. "Ramuji showcases his heroines beautifully. It's a good start for me," she says. And if Nisha Kothari or Antara Mali's 'success' factors are anything to go by, then that's the path 26-year-old Sikander has chosen to tread. Her film *Dhoom Dhadaka*, a situational comedy with Sameer Dattani, is awaiting release. "I want to do roles which allow me to show my talent," says Sikander. And what better way of doing that than an item number?

Sangeeta Ghosh, 26

Better known as: Pammi of *Des Mein Nikla Hoga Chaand*.
The makeover: Will be seen as sultry Priya in Darshan's next.

